

these things during the challenge, but it's helpful to prepare in advance if you know you'll run out in the next few weeks.

You'll also want to make a meal plan. We recommend making it for one to two weeks, but you may want to meal plan just once for the entire thirty days. Focus on meals that are easier (or almost easier) than ordering takeout. This isn't the month to start tracking macros or try Whole30. Focus on one challenge at a time. Last, you'll want to plan things to do. A no-spend challenge isn't a stay-at-home challenge. You know all those free activities you've been wanting to do? All those gift cards you've been hoarding? The hobby supplies you bought but haven't used yet? The free events sections of Facebook and Eventbrite? Go take advantage of them! This is the month to try new (free) things.

If this is your first no-spend challenge, we do recommend abstaining from all nonessentials to get the most out of it. A no-spend challenge allows you to remove the clutter of daily spending decisions so you can think clearly about your desires. The more exceptions you allow, the harder the challenge becomes, and the less you ultimately get out of it.

2. Abstain

Now it's time to practice. We say "practice" intentionally because that's what this is. Having a perfect no-spend month isn't the goal. During your no-spend challenge, take advantage of the space this short season creates to get curious. Here are some questions to journal about to better understand your spending habits. Record your thoughts while the events of the day are still fresh in your mind. Your notes will be a helpful resource to review once you've completed the challenge.

Each time the desire to shop comes up: What needs was I trying to meet by shopping?

What are the problems my unintentional spending has created?

What problems have unintentional spending held me back from solving?

What painful emotions is this challenge bringing up?

Am I judging myself for my performance during this challenge?

What are the next steps I want to accomplish with the knowledge I've gained from this challenge?

You'll also want to tell the people around you about your challenge. It'll be a little awkward, but trust us, it's worth it. I (Jen) posted daily to